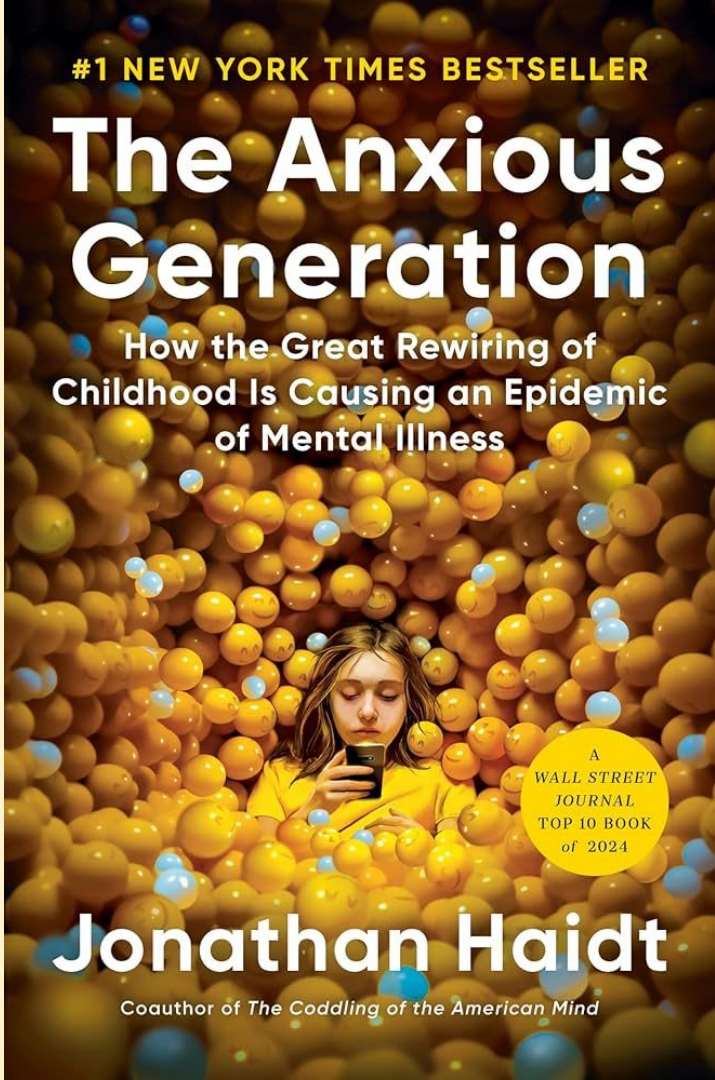
The Anxious Generation

By Jonathan Haidt

Bradley Allen
Emily Strickland
Sophia Rabbanian



Haidt’s Main Claim

- Childhood rewired fast with smartphones and social platforms
- Kids entered complex online spaces without preparation
- Emotional development and digital demands did not match
- Adults were also unprepared for the new environment

Why Data Ethics Matters Here

- The issue is not only screen time
- Children entered systems built for extraction and engagement
- Data collection and tracking were designed to platforms from the start
- Kids became users before meaningful protections existed

UNICEF: Global Digital Childhood

- Internet access became a necessity for social and academic life
- Massive gaps remain, with two thirds of school-aged kids lacking home internet
  - High-connectivity countries face overexposure and mental health strain
  - Low-connectivity countries face exclusion from digital skills
- Shared pattern:
  - Technology arrives first, protections later

Pew: What Teens Think They Control

- Teens share a lot of personal information but feel confident with privacy settings
- They focus on managing social visibility, not data flows
- Only a small percentage are very concerned about advertisers
- Parents worry more, but their own practices often add to data exposure

Datafication Begins Early

- Mascheroni et al. show that data traces start long before adolescence
- Sharenting (the practice of sharing news, images, or videos of one's children on social media, especially in a way regarded as excessive), GPS tracking, and IoT toys (Internet of Things: toys embedded with sensors, software, and other technologies that allow them to connect and exchange data over the internet) build early digital identities.
- Children try to push back with multiple accounts, deletions, or fake information
- They care about privacy, but control is limited

Hand’s Data Ethics Framework

- Consent is hard to make meaningful when future uses are unknown
- Data ownership is unclear and often shared
- Data shadows persist even after deletion
  - Unknown, hidden, or overlooked copies of sensitive information that exist outside the purview of an organization’s IT security measures
- Limited transparency intensifies risks for young users

Bringing It Back to Haidt

- Haidt describes the psychological impact of early digital immersion
- Data ethics shows the structural impact behind it
- Kids face social pressure and long-term data exposure at the same time
- Their childhood was shaped by systems that did not prioritize their well-being

Teen Addiction

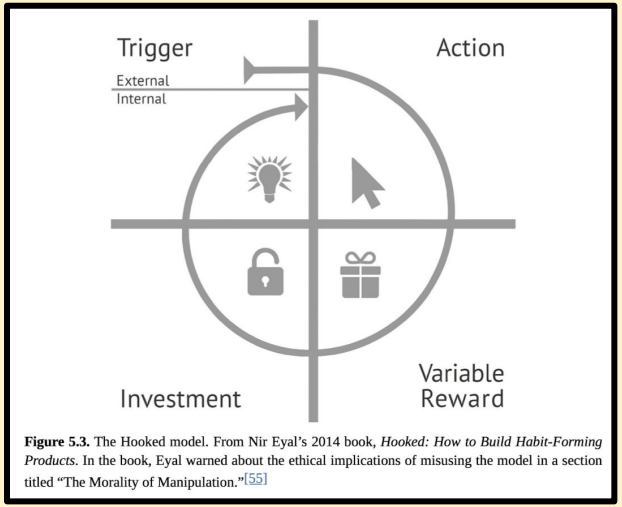


Figure 5.3. The Hooked model. From Nir Eyal's 2014 book, *Hooked: How to Build Habit-Forming Products*. In the book, Eyal warned about the ethical implications of misusing the model in a section titled "The Morality of Manipulation."[55]

- Hooked Model
  - Dopamine Release
- Apps wish to maximize screen time
  - Psychological dynamics of slot machines
- AI-driven algorithms
  - Increasingly personalized content, keeping user online
- Easy to lose track of time on these apps
  - Bottomless feed of personalized content
- Balance between communication and media consumption
  - Benefits of online connections, harms of compulsive engagement

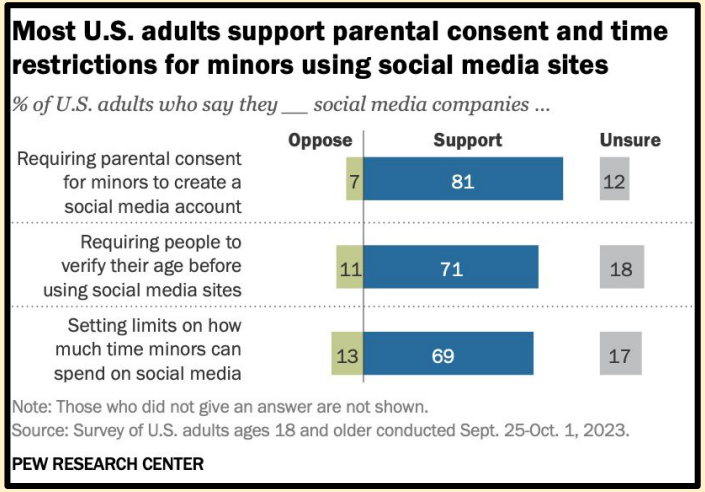
Attention Spans



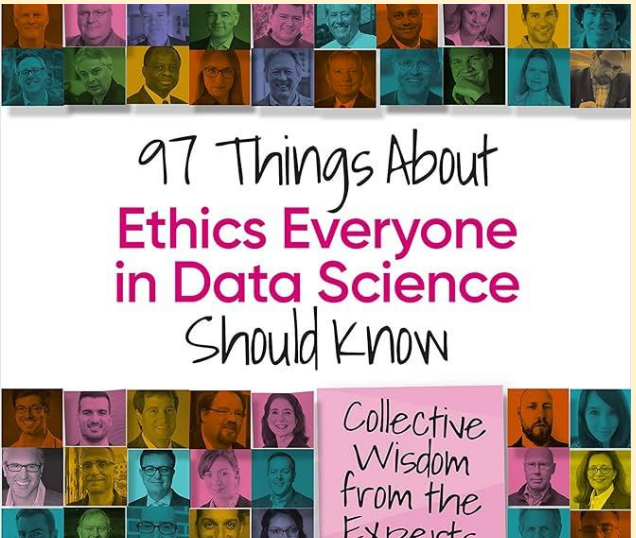
- Two types of attention: **focused and rote**
- Connection to Haidt - decrease in unsupervised play
- Average attention span
  - 2004: 2.5 minutes w/o getting distracted
  - 2023: 40 seconds w/o getting distracted
- Switching costs
  - Time it takes to reorient yourself with the task you got distracted from
  - Wastes time, wastes effort
- Especially harmful for children
  - Mostly rote activities from a young age
  - Missing opportunities to develop

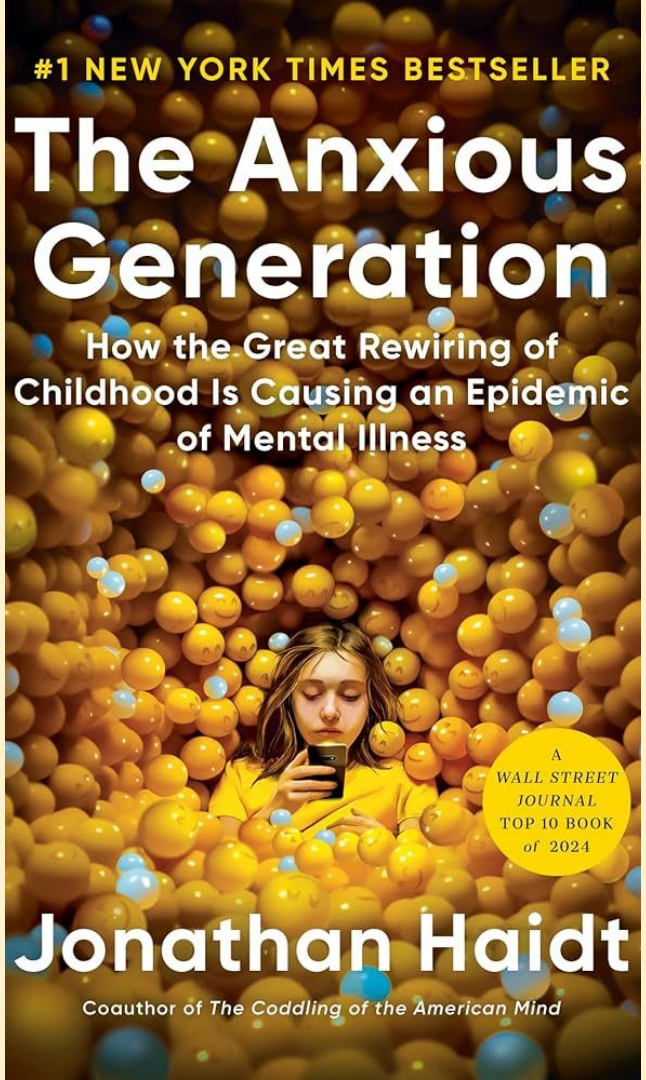
Public Opinion on Regulations

- Haidt's **4** norms:
  - No smartphones before 14
  - No social media until 16
  - Phone-free schools
  - More unsupervised play and childhood independence
- Trend towards keeping children inside
  - Avoiding physical harm, increasing psychological harm
- Children with stricter phone rules isolated from peers
  - Strike balance between socially isolating your child and avoiding unhealthy phone habits
- Australia's age restriction represents strong middle ground
  - Hopefully other countries will follow









Biology 102, CRN

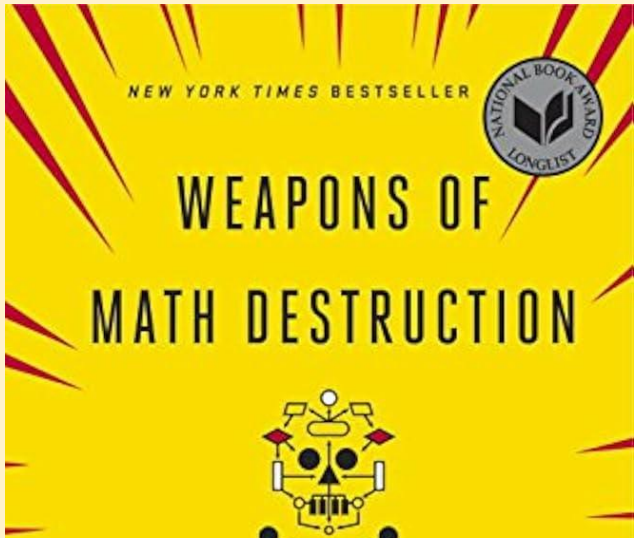
[DATE]

What Hath Tech Wrought?

Father, give us courage to change what must be altered, serenity to accept what cannot be helped, and the insight to know the one from the other.

– Reinhold Niebuhr (1937, as cited in Shapiro, 2010).

In the Bible, a man named Balaam was sent by a king to curse the people of Israel, but when Balaam observed God was with Jacob and his people in Israel, and that God's presence bestowed power and harmony upon them, Balaam, out of wonder and amazement asked, *What hath God wrought!?* (American Standard Version Bible, n.d., Numbers 23:23). In 2022, a power of another sort was unleashed on humanity: generative pre-trained transformer (GPT) artificial intelligence (AI). GPT AI, such as ChatGPT, has the potential to demonstrate human behavior, including holding a conversation (OpenAI, 2022). As AI approaches human levels of intelligence, and San Francisco based company OpenAI is closing the gap with ChatGPT, humanity stands on the precipice of an existential crisis. In the United States, Americans, like



Secular Morality

Pew Research Center

REPORT | JANUARY 24, 2024

Religious 'Nones' in America: Who They Are and What They Believe

A closer look at how atheists, agnostics and those who describe their religion as 'nothing in particular' see God, religion, morality, science and more

Add Us On Google



28% of U.S. adults are now religiously unaffiliated

% of U.S. adults who identify religiously as atheist, agnostic or "nothing in particular"

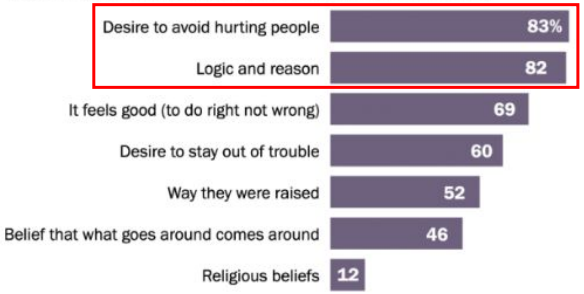


Source: 2020-23 data based on Pew Research Center's National Public Opinion Reference Surveys, nationally representative surveys conducted online and by mail; respondents recruited using address-based sampling. Data from 2019 and earlier comes from the Center's random-digit-dial phone surveys, including the 2007 and 2014 Religious Landscape Studies.
"Religious 'Nones' in America: Who They Are and What They Believe"

PEW RESEARCH CENTER

83% of 'nones' say desire to not hurt people key to deciding right from wrong

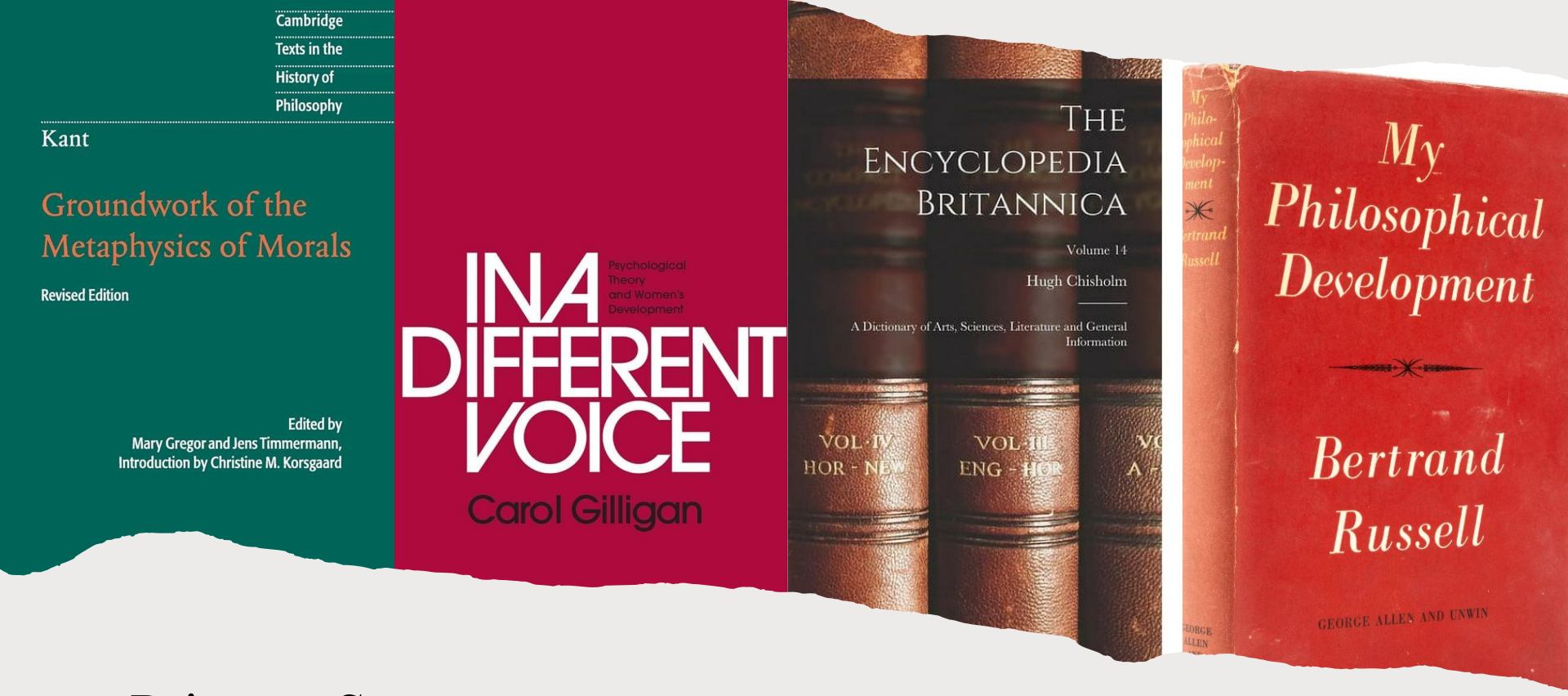
*% of religious "nones" who say each of the following is **extremely or very important** when making decisions between right and wrong*



Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted July 31-Aug. 6, 2023.
"Religious 'Nones' in America: Who They Are and What They Believe"

PEW RESEARCH CENTER

https://pewrsr.ch/3SedVTm



Primary Sources

Review of Common Moral Frameworks

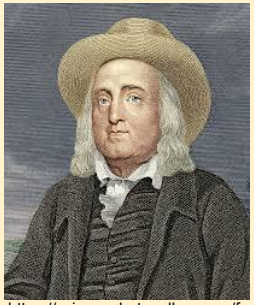
Deontology



https://fixquotes.com/authors/immanuel-kant.htm

- Inherent dignity
- Right is independent of the outcome
- Humans are an end, not a means

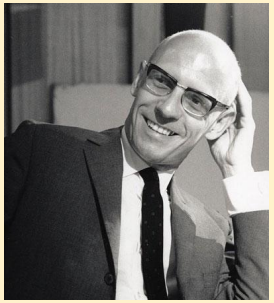
Utilitarianism



https://sciencephotogallery.com/featured/jeremy-bentham-british-philosopher-sheila-terry.html

- Can they suffer?
- Right is dependent on the outcome
- Max pleasure, min harm

Postmodernism



https://contemporarythinkers.org/michel-foucault/biography/

- Knowledge is an expression of power
- Nothing has objective meaning
- All morals are equal b/c all are arbitrary

Findings



Deontology

- Better for governance
  - Categorical imperative
- Male-centric
  - Incorporate Care Ethics
- Assumes reason is normative
  - Reason develops over time



Utilitarianism

- Better for individual choice
- Can justify bad outcomes



Postmodernism

"*This is one of those views which [is] so absurd that only very learned men could possibly adopt [it].*"
~ Bertram Russell

Categorical imperative: *Act in accordance with a maxim that can at the same time make itself a universal law*

Conclusion

Framework

- An algorithm must be designed such that its creator is at the same time subject to the analysis and disclosure rules of the algorithm
- No algorithm is ethical if it…
  - Inhibits the formation of hierarchical systems of competency
  - Undermines interpersonal relationships or is arbitrarily / tyrannically exclusive
  - Takes advantage of individual whose capacity for reason is developing
  - Diminishes human dignity (e.g., treats people as a means)

Purpose

- To be clear, this is a calculus, not a solution.
- It is a tool for data scientists to evaluate whether their algorithms treat users as a means or an end.
- This is meant to be the starting point in a long continuum of data ethics.

Thank You!

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